SEC Filings Quick Reference

What each main US company filing is for, what it contains, and how to use it to judge a company's moat, its history and its outlook.

> All filings are free on SEC EDGAR (sec.gov/edgar/search). Deadlines below are the general rules from the SEC's own form instructions and Investor.gov, checked 2026-11-05; see Sources on the last page. This guide explains documents; it does not recommend any security.

1. The filings at a glance

Filing	What it is	When it is filed	Audited?	Most useful for
10-K	Annual report: the full picture of the business, its risks, management's discussion and complete financial statements	60 days after year end (large accelerated filers), 75 days (accelerated), 90 days (others)	Yes	Moat, long-term history, risks
10-Q	Quarterly report: financial statements, management's discussion, changes in risk factors	For each of the first 3 quarters: 40 days (large accelerated and accelerated), 45 days (others)	No (reviewed)	Recent trend, early warnings
8-K	Current report: one major event, filed as it happens	Generally within 4 business days of the event	No	News, results, guidance, management changes
DEF 14A	Proxy statement: notice of the shareholder meeting, executive pay, board, items to vote on	Before the annual meeting	No	Management incentives, governance
Form 4	Insider (officer, director, over-10% holder) buys and sells	Within 2 business days of the trade	No	Insider behaviour
13D / 13G	A person or group now owns more than 5%. 13D = may seek change (activist); 13G = shorter form for passive holders	13D: within 5 days of the purchase	No	Who is accumulating shares
13F	Quarterly list of US stock holdings of managers with at least $100 million	Within 45 days of quarter end	No	What large funds own
S-1 / 424B	Registration statement and prospectus for an IPO or new offering	Before the offering	Yes (accounts)	The deepest one-time business description
20-F / 6-K	Foreign private issuers' annual report and current report (similar to 10-K and 8-K)	20-F: within 4 months of year end	20-F: yes	Non-US companies (often IFRS)
10-K/A, 10-Q/A	Amendment correcting or adding to an earlier report	As needed	Depends	Restatements, missing Part III

2. Inside the 10-K (annual report)

The single most important document. Read the same sections across several years: what changes tells you as much as what is written.

Section	What it covers	What to look for
Item 1 Business	Products, customers, markets, competitors, patents, regulation, employees	How the company says it wins; customer concentration; named competitors
Item 1A Risk Factors	Material risks as management sees them	New risks year over year (new competitor, pricing pressure, key customer loss)
Item 1C Cybersecurity	How cyber risk is managed and governed	Weak oversight in data-heavy businesses
Item 3 Legal Proceedings	Material lawsuits and investigations	Cases that threaten a core product or patent
Item 5 Market for Equity	Share data, dividends, buybacks	How capital is returned to owners
Item 7 MD&A	Management explains results, trends, liquidity, outlook factors	Drivers of growth and margin; whether explanations keep changing
Item 7A Market Risk	Interest-rate, currency and commodity exposure	Sensitivity of profits to factors outside management's control
Item 8 Financial Statements	Audited income statement, balance sheet, cash flows, notes, auditor's report	Return on capital, margins, cash conversion; notes on revenue, debt, leases, segments
Item 9A Controls	Effectiveness of internal control over financial reporting	Any material weakness is a red flag
Part III (Items 10-14)	Directors, executive pay, ownership, related parties, auditor fees	Often 'incorporated by reference' from the proxy (DEF 14A)

Inside the 10-Q (quarterly report)

Section	What it covers
Part I, Item 1	Unaudited financial statements for the quarter and year to date
Part I, Item 2 MD&A	Quarter's results and trends; liquidity
Part I, Items 3-4	Market risk; controls and procedures
Part II, Item 1A	Only changes to the risk factors since the 10-K: worth reading every time
Part II, Item 2	Share buybacks during the quarter

3. 8-K items worth knowing

Every 8-K lists its item numbers on the cover and in EDGAR, so you can scan them without opening the document. Item names below are from the SEC's Form 8-K.

Item	Event	Why it matters
1.01 / 1.02	Material agreement entered into / terminated	Big contracts, partnerships, credit lines
1.03	Bankruptcy or receivership	Severe distress
1.05	Material cybersecurity incident	Operational and reputational damage
2.01	Acquisition or disposal of assets completed	Changes what the business is

Item	Event	Why it matters
2.02	Results of operations (earnings release, usually Exhibit 99.1)	First look at results; often includes guidance
2.03	New direct financial obligation	New debt
2.05 / 2.06	Exit or disposal costs / material impairment	Restructuring; write-downs of past investments
3.01	Delisting notice or failure of a listing rule	Exchange compliance problem
4.01	Change of auditor	Ask why
4.02	Earlier financial statements can no longer be relied on	Restatement: a serious red flag
5.01	Change in control	Takeover or new controlling holder
5.02	Directors or officers leave or are appointed; pay arrangements	CEO or CFO turnover
5.07	Shareholder vote results	Support for pay and board
7.01 / 8.01	Regulation FD disclosure / other events	Investor presentations, other news
9.01	Financial statements and exhibits	The attached documents

4. Using filings for investment research

Three questions, and where the evidence is.

Question	Best sources	Evidence for	Warning signs
Is there a moat?	10-K Items 1, 1A, 7, 8; S-1 for newer companies	Return on invested capital well above the cost of capital for many years; stable or rising gross margin (pricing power); recurring revenue and retention; leading share; patents, network effects, switching costs, scale, licences described concretely	Margins falling while revenue grows; new competition named in Risk Factors; dependence on a few customers
What happened before?	Several years of 10-Ks and 10-Qs; 8-K items 2.01, 2.06, 4.01, 4.02, 5.02	Steady growth funded by cash flow; acquisitions that earned their cost; consistent explanations in MD&A	Restatements; write-downs after acquisitions; frequent CEO or CFO changes; auditor changes; material weakness
What lies ahead?	8-K item 2.02 (guidance); 10-K MD&A; notes on remaining performance obligations (contracted future revenue); DEF 14A; Form 4	Growing contracted backlog; planned investment with a clear return; executive pay tied to return on capital or per-share value; insider buying	Guidance cut; pay tied only to size (revenue, adjusted EBITDA); heavy insider selling; rising debt for buybacks

> Filings mostly describe the past. Guidance and plans are management's own statements: unaudited, carrying legal cautions, and sometimes wrong. Earnings-call transcripts are usually not filed with the SEC. Treat forward-looking statements as hypotheses to test against later filings.

5. A reading order for a new company

- **Latest 10-K, Item 1:** what the company sells, to whom, and how it says it wins.
- **Item 8 over 5-10 years:** revenue growth, gross and operating margin, return on capital, free cash flow, debt.
- **Item 1A, compared with 2-3 years ago:** which risks are new or reworded.

- **Item 7 MD&A:** do management's explanations match the numbers?
- **Latest 10-Qs:** is the trend holding? Read Part II Item 1A for changed risks.
- **8-Ks since the last 10-K:** scan item numbers; open 2.02 (results), 4.02, 5.02, 2.06 first.
- **DEF 14A:** how executives are paid, and on which measures.
- **Form 4 and 13D/13G:** what insiders and large holders are doing.

6. How the Moat Momentum dashboard uses filings today

Filing	Used today	Not used yet
10-K / 10-Q	All numbers (XBRL values as filed, point in time) and page numbers in the Excel calculation sheet; Item 1 description in the Deep-Dive	Risk Factors, MD&A text
8-K	Filing list only; item numbers 1.03 and 5.01 in the back-test of earlier versions; latest 8-K link saved in the data	Content of events and press releases; the saved link is not shown on the page
DEF 14A, Form 4, 13D/G, 13F	Not used	Executive pay, insider and holder activity

Sources (accessed 2026-11-05)

SEC, Form 10-K and General Instructions (filing deadlines 60/75/90 days): https://www.sec.gov/files/form10-k.pdf

SEC, Form 10-Q and General Instructions (40/45 days): https://www.sec.gov/files/form10-q.pdf

SEC, Form 8-K and General Instructions (item list; four business days): https://www.sec.gov/files/form8-k.pdf

SEC, Form 13F instructions (USD 100 million; 45 days): https://www.sec.gov/files/form13f.pdf

SEC, Form 20-F General Instructions (four months): https://www.sec.gov/files/form20-f.pdf

SEC, Forms 3, 4 and 5 investor bulletin (Form 4 within two business days): https://www.sec.gov/files/forms-3-4-5.pdf

Investor.gov, Form 10-K: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/form-10-k

Investor.gov, Form 10-Q: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/form-10-q

Investor.gov, Form 8-K: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/form-8-k

Investor.gov, Proxy Statements: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/proxy-statements

Investor.gov, Schedules 13D and 13G (13D within five days): https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/schedules-13d-and-13g

Investor.gov, Registration Statement (Form S-1): https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/registration-statement

SEC EDGAR full-text and company search: https://www.sec.gov/edgar/search/